

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

What's News

Business & Finance

- ◆ **Banks wrapped up** the sale of \$5.5 billion in floating-rate debt backed by the X social-media company, increasing the sum from a planned total of about \$3 billion. **A1**
- ◆ **Americans contributing** to 401(k) accounts brought the participation numbers to half of private-sector workers after years of growing enrollment in the retirement plans. **A1**
- ◆ **Major U.S. stock indexes** notched modest gains, with the S&P 500, Dow and Nasdaq rising 0.4%, 0.7% and 0.2%, respectively. **B10**
- ◆ **The U.S. trade deficit** grew again at the end of last year as exports slipped, widening a gap the new administration has vowed to address. **A2**
- ◆ **Streaming gains** bolstered Disney's performance in the final three months of 2024, adding momentum to the company's effort to turn Disney+ into a principal entertainment hub. **B1**
- ◆ **Novo Nordisk reported** strong sales growth for its blockbuster obesity and diabetes drugs and issued a forecast for 2025 results that beat analysts' expectations. **B1**
- ◆ **The SEC, eager to bury** its conflict with the crypto market, moved its top litigator to an office that maintains the agency's computer systems. **B1**
- ◆ **Google eliminated** its goal of hiring more employees from historically underrepresented groups and is reviewing some DEI programs. **B4**
- ◆ **Volkswagen outlined** a five-year plan for its name-sake brand that includes launching a new low-cost electric car as the company plots a path to growth. **B3**

World-Wide

- ◆ **Major Middle East** powers rejected Trump's surprise proposal for the U.S. to take control of Gaza, redevelop the enclave and move Palestinians out permanently, a notion that breaks with decades of U.S. and international policy toward the region. **A1, A8, A10**
- ◆ **Representatives of** Musk's DOGE have been working at the Centers for Medicare and Medicaid Services, where they have gained access to payment and contracting systems. **A3**
- ◆ **Attorney General Pam Bondi** moved swiftly to align the Justice Department toward Trump's desire to investigate his past legal adversaries. **A3**
- ◆ **The U.S. said a deal** has been reached with Panama on free canal passage for U.S. government ships, surprising Panamanian officials before formal completion of the accord. **A6**
- ◆ **New HUD Secretary** Turner said a cross-government effort to privatize Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac is a priority. **A2**
- ◆ **House Republicans** considered an extension of Trump's expiring tax cuts that would last as little as five years in a nod to the party's deficit hawks. **A4**
- ◆ **More than 100** workers in the EPA's environmental justice and civil-rights office are expected to be placed on administrative leave by the Trump administration. **A3**
- ◆ **U.N. agencies expressed** concern about Pakistan's decision to deport thousands of Afghan refugees awaiting relocation to the U.S. and elsewhere. **A8**
- ◆ **Died: Harry Stewart Jr.**, 100, Tuskegee Airmen veteran. **A2**

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Mexicans Deploy Troops to Border



GUILLEMO ARAS/AGENCE FRANCE PRESSE/GETTY IMAGES

BOOTS ON THE GROUND: A Mexico National Guard officer was posted at the border with the U.S. in Playas de Tijuana, Baja California state, Wednesday, as part of a 10,000-person deployment in exchange for the U.S. holding off on a tariff on imports from Mexico.

Musk's Clout in Washington Turbocharges Sale of X Debt

By ALEXANDER SAEEDY AND JUSTIN BAER

Elon Musk's power in Washington and the return of big advertisers like Amazon have Wall Street clamoring to get a piece of X.

Banks wrapped up the sale of \$5.5 billion in debt backed by Musk's social-media company on Wednesday, people familiar with the matter said. The banks had originally planned to sell around \$3 billion at around 95 cents on the

dollar, The Wall Street Journal had reported. They upsized the deal after seeing demand from investors, the people said.

In the end, investors, including Pimco and Citadel, agreed to buy the loans at 97 cents on the dollar. The floating-rate debts carry an interest rate of about 11%, with borrowing costs several percentage points above even the riskiest loans on Wall Street.

The sale of X Corp.'s loans showcase the animal spirits that have taken over Wall

Street since Donald Trump's election in November. Investors are also eager to bet on Musk, given his proximity to President Trump and growing influence since the election.

Musk's social-media company stumbled when advertisers fled the platform en masse after he bought the company in 2022. While some advertisers have returned, X is still

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◆ **Democrats turn focus on Musk.....** A4

Mideast Powers Reject Trump's Gaza Proposal

Saudis, Turkey rule out U.S. takeover, reaffirm support for Palestinian cause

By RORY JONES AND OMAR ABDEL-BAQUI

DUBAI—Major Middle East powers rejected President Trump's surprise proposal for the U.S. to take control of Gaza, redevelop the enclave and move Palestinians out permanently, pointing to the challenges ahead for a notion that breaks with decades of U.S. and international policy toward the region.

Saudi Arabia, which the U.S. hopes to lead into a deal to normalize ties with Israel, said Wednesday it rejected

any efforts to displace Palestinians from their land and reaffirmed support for a Palestinian state. It called its position nonnegotiable and said it wouldn't establish diplomatic relations with Israel unless that goal was met.

The foreign minister of Turkey, a North Atlantic Treaty Organization member, called Trump's idea "absurd" and said the country opposed displacement of Palestinians or any "initiatives that try to take the people of Gaza out of the equation."

Egypt, Jordan, the United Arab Emirates, Qatar and Palestinian leaders in recent weeks have also rejected the idea of

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◆ **Proposal risks becoming a distraction** A10

President Veers Into Foreign Intervention

WASHINGTON—President Trump campaigned on shrinking the U.S.'s role abroad. But since taking office, he has articulated a worldview that is at times closer to expansionism than isolationism.

By Alex Leary, Josh Dawsey and Alexander Ward

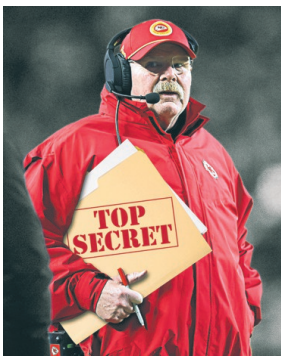
Trump generated global shock waves Tuesday when he said the U.S. should take long-term control of Gaza, suggesting Palestinians should be relocated while the enclave is rebuilt into the "Riviera of the Middle East." U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio wrote on social media that Trump would "Make Gaza Beautiful Again."

Taking control of the territory would put the U.S. at the center of one of the world's most complicated diplomatic and national-security conflicts, raising the prospect that Trump is signing the country up for exactly the kind of foreign entanglement he told voters he would avoid. Trump didn't rule out sending U.S. troops to Gaza to accomplish his goals.

On Wednesday, White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt said that taxpayers wouldn't cover the cost of developing the territory and that any Palestinian relocation would be temporary. She stressed that the president hadn't yet committed to send-

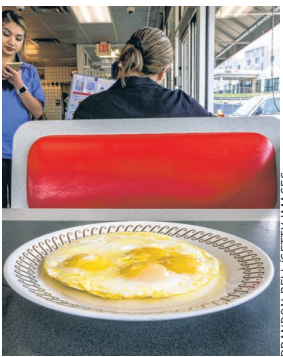
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INSIDE



SPORTS

The biggest mystery of the Super Bowl: Do the Chiefs have a secret playbook? **A16**



BUSINESS & FINANCE

Some restaurants are responding to egg shortage with an added fee. **B1**

401(k)s Reach a Tipping Point In Takeover of U.S. Retirement

By ANNE TERGESEN

It took nearly 50 years, but half of private-sector workers are saving in 401(k)s for the first time.

Long after workplaces started using these retirement plans in place of traditional pensions, they are finally reaching a tipping point. Around 70% of private-sector employees in the U.S. now have access to a 401(k)-style retirement plan. A decade earlier, 60% had access and 43% contributed, according to the

U.S. Labor Department. Policymakers have moved in recent years to broaden access. More states are requiring companies to offer a retirement savings option. Congress has given small businesses more generous incentives to launch them. And companies are automatically enrolling more workers, substantially raising participation rates.

Growth in worker adoption is likely to accelerate due to a federal law that went into effect this year, requiring many new 401(k) plans to use auto-

matic enrollment. "More people are covered and more are participating, fees are coming down," said David Stinnett, head of strategic retirement consulting at Vanguard. "But there's work left to be done."

Even though adoption has picked up recently, about 40% of the working population isn't saving enough to maintain their lifestyle throughout retirement, according to Boston College's Center for Retirement Research.

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Parents Are Drowning In Gibberish

What the sigma? New slang leaves adults confounded

By KATHERINE BINDLEY

Cecilia Hermawan has text chains going with other parents to stay up to speed on the words and phrases catching on among their children. Still, the Boston-area resident was taken aback after hearing the word "mewing" come out of her 9-year-old's mouth.

"I didn't know what it meant so I had to Google it, and I had to ask my friend Emily to reference check," said Hermawan, 41.

The startup founder was relieved her daughter and her friend were referring to a type of facial exercise and not something inappropriate.

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Russian TV Star Sells Kremlin Agenda

Dmitry Kiselyov serves as Putin's propagandist in chief

By MATTHEW LUXMOORE

For tens of millions of television viewers across Russia's 11 time zones, Sunday night means tuning in to watch Dmitry Kiselyov.

The country's most influential news anchor, Kiselyov has for over a decade interpreted world events for the nation, as Walter Cronkite or Dan Rather once did for the U.S. His weekly current affairs show, "News of the Week," at first glance seems similar to any news bulletin on CNN or the BBC.

The message he broadcasts is anything but. There are breathless updates on Russia's military advances, with cinematic shots of jet fighters pounding Ukrainian towns. Clips from pride parades in

San Francisco are shown as evidence the U.S. verges on collapse. Kiselyov recently struck a positive note on President Trump, echoing the Kremlin, but warned that his tariff threats might torpedo Russia's good will toward him.

One recent report began with an apocalyptic warning to the West: Russia won't hesitate to use nuclear bombs if it feels threatened. Footage of President Vladimir Putin addressing Kremlin officials was interspersed with clips of missiles flying through the air.

"Don't complain later," Kiselyov intoned in his trademark raspy voice. "Don't tell us that we didn't warn you."

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◆ **Kremlin says U.S. talks on Ukraine heat up.....** A12

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